

possible view is that Ezra, on his arrival with firman and lawbook, found the former quite useless owing to the temper of the people, and waited thirteen years before he ventured publicly to introduce the latter. Others think that the narrator meant something quite different, viz., that Ezra did not think it important to feel his way and try his powers of persuasion, but at once introduced the law amidst the rejoicings of the multitude. I think myself that the latter view of the writer's meaning is the most natural one, but I find it not less difficult to accept as historical than the former. How, except by an appeal to force, Ezra can have won immediate acceptance for his lawbook, I do not understand. Did he make such an appeal, according to the document? No. The statement is that "all the people. . . spoke to Ezra the scribe to bring the book of the Law of Moses which Jehovah had commanded Israel" (Neh. viii., 1), and that on the next day the heads of families joined the priests and Levites in a visit to the great legal expert, Ezra, to learn the orthodox mode of keeping the Feast of Booths. Now I do not deny that there was at this time a sincere attachment on the part of the leading Judæans to the older law, and I fully recognise the moral influence which must have been exerted by the new settlers from Babylonia, but I doubt whether a lawbook dif-

fering so widely from the older one (I will explain what Ezra's lawbook was presently), can have been at once accepted by the whole people and especially by the aristocratic class. True, the other view appears not less questionable. How can Ezra have waited thirteen years before he obeyed, and that most imperfectly, the plain command of Artaxerxes? I must confess, too, that the events which, according to the extant records, followed this supposed publication and solemn acceptance of the law confirm me in my sceptical attitude. I can partly understand the story of the introduction of the older lawbook under Josiah, but I cannot in the least comprehend the externally parallel narrative in Neh. viii. A small kernel of fact may not unreasonably be admitted. But the story, as it stands, is, I greatly fear, unhistorical.

Not less full of improbability is the story of the marriage-reforms in Ezra ix., x. Such a delicate matter as the alteration of marriage-customs cannot have been brought about so quickly and in such a rough-and-ready way. That the sight of Ezra, sitting with dishevelled hair in a stupor, and then the hearing of a solemn liturgical prayer, should have so unnerved the people who had married non-Jewish wives that they straightway volunteered to turn away their wives and their children, and that three days

afterwards a still larger assembly should have gathered in cold rainy weather in the open air, and sanctioned the appointment of a commission to compel the offenders to carry out this resolution, is surely incredible. That there was anything like a general dismissal of non-Jewish wives and their children, not only psychological considerations, but certain important facts recorded in our documents * forbid us to believe.

Let no one suppose that I am trying to convert Ezra into a model of humanity. On the contrary, I think it likely that he was at first far too vehement in his language and rigorous in his demands, and I must express a fear that some too pliant persons may have given way to him. If these surmises are correct, the scribe Ezra was guilty of a distinct denial of the divine fatherhood—a doctrine expressed in the very first chapter of the narrative which introduces his lawbook. I am bound to denounce this as much as I sympathise with and admire the very different attitude of the apostle Paul. Nor can I help referring in this connection to the blessings which accrued to the English race through the union of a heathen king of Kent with a Christian princess from France. Gratitude for these blessings compels me to shrink with horror from the conduct of Ezra, if he gave

* See Ezr. x., 15 ; Neh. xiii., 23-27.

sufficient occasion for a narrative like that in Ezra ix., x.

And yet, even if Ezra was so far guilty, I must not ignore the existence of extenuating circumstances. This vehemence and rigour (so far as they are historical) were but the excess of his religious patriotism. They arose out of his dread of the too possible disastrous consequences of mixed marriages. A child is always affected permanently for good or for evil by the religion of its mother. There was a time when the religion of ancient Egypt became partly Semitic through the intermarriage of Egyptians and Syrians, and some of the least desirable religious peculiarities of the early Israelites were largely due to their intermarriage with the Canaanites. That was chiefly why Ezra and Nehemiah were so much opposed to mixed marriages. The religion which they desired to promote was a book-religion, which to a considerable extent recognised the claims of development; those of the Samaritans and the other small nations of Palestine were local, unprogressive religions, based on ancient custom. No doubt Ezra's policy was opposed to the doctrine of the divine fatherhood expressed in the first chapter of Genesis. But we can show from the Book of Malachi * that many of those with whom Ezra would

* Mal. ii., 10-16.

fain have dealt so barbarously had offered an equally flat contradiction to that great doctrine by turning adrift the Jewish wives whom they had married in their youth in order to marry foreign women. "Have we not all one Father? has not one God created us?" are the words in which Malachi indignantly reproves them. He also mentions the sad divisions in families which had arisen from these cruel divorces, the children having apparently taken the part of their disgraced mothers. And he seems to have painfully felt his own inability to reform this abuse, for he (or some not much later writer) has added this appendix to his prophecy,—

"Behold, I send you the prophet Elijah before Jehovah's great and terrible day come. He shall turn the hearts of the fathers to the children, and the hearts of the children to their fathers, lest I come and smite the land with a curse" (Mal. iv., 5, 6).

In other words, Malachi looked for a great religious reformer, who should make the people think of their family and social obligations, and of Jehovah's hatred for all un-Israelitish conduct. Jehovah had made no covenant except with Israel; those who formed an alliance of any kind, either with half-Jews like the Samaritans, or with non-Jews like the Philistines, Ammonites, and Moabites, and who, in order to do this, had put away their Jewish wives, provoked His

displeasure. Such, too, we may presume was the theory of marriage inculcated by Ezra.

Very little, then, remains to the critical historian of the details of the story in Ezra ix., x. A somewhat more favourable judgment can, in my opinion, be passed on the account of the rise of the so-called congregation, or to borrow a more appropriate Greek term, the *Ecclesia*.^{*} This narrative seems originally to have followed on that in Ezr. ix., x., the last words of which, as given in the true Septuagint text, are "and they dismissed them (*i. e.*, their foreign wives) with their children." It also undoubtedly presupposes that Ezra's lawbook had been generally accepted and was now in force. For it speaks of a long reading from the book of the law of Jehovah as having preceded the liturgical confession uttered by the Levites; the contents of the lawbook were something quite new to the audience. Now it is quite true that this cannot be the historical background of the formation of the congregation. The mixed marriages cannot to any great extent have been dissolved, and the lawbook of Ezra cannot have been generally or publicly accepted. But the scene in the foreground of the picture may still be correct. The Babylonian Jews who came up with Ezra certainly regarded themselves as the true Israelites, and it was

^{*} Cf., Hort, *The Christian Ecclesia* (1896).